



Colorado Employment First FFY2026 Program Operator Handbook

State of Colorado, Department of Human Services
SNAP Employment and Training

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This handbook is a living document and is subject to change throughout the 2026 Federal Fiscal Year.

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Acronyms

Below is a list of common acronyms.

Acronym	Term
ABAWD	Able-Bodied Adult Without Dependents
CBMS	Colorado Benefits Management System
CCCAP	Colorado Child Care Assistance Program
CDHE	Colorado Department of Higher Education
CDHS	Colorado Department of Human Services (this acronym is for the Colorado State Department of Human Services, not the County Human Services Departments)
CDLE	Colorado Department of Labor and Employment
CFMS	County Financial Management System
CFR	Code of Federal Regulations
CUBS	Colorado Unemployment Benefits System
CWDC	Colorado Workforce Development Council
DHS	Department of Human Services (this acronym is for County Human Services Departments, not the Colorado State Department of Human Services)
DVR	Department of Vocational Rehabilitation
DEWS	Division of Economic and Workforce Support
EF	Employment First
EF PO	Employment First Program Operator (includes county human services departments and Third-Party Partners)
E&T	Employment and Training
EW	Eligibility Worker

FAFSA	Free Application for Federal Student Aid
FDPIR	Food Distribution Program on Indian Reservation
FEAD	Food and Energy Assistance Division (the CDHS Division that supervises Colorado's SNAP program)
FFY	Federal Fiscal Year
FNS	Food and Nutrition Services
GA	General Assistance
ISP	Individualized Service Plan
ITO	Indian Tribal Organization
LMI	Labor Market Information
LOE	Level of Effort
MCJ	My Colorado Journey
ME	Management Evaluation
NOA	Notice of Action
NOAA	Notice of Adverse Action
OIT	Office of Information Technology
OJT	On-the-Job Training
PR	Participant Reimbursement
PD	Provider Determination
RMWDA	Rocky Mountain Workforce Development Council
SJS	Supervised Job Search
SNAP	Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program
SOW	Statement of Work
SUIT	Southern Ute Indian Tribe
TANF	Temporary Assistance for Needy Families
TPP	Third-Party Partner
UMUT	Ute Mountain Ute Tribe

USDA	United States Department of Agriculture
USDOL	United States Department of Labor
WF	Workfare
WIOA	Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act
WBL	Work-based Learning
WDP	Workforce Development Program

Summary of Employment First

Federal regulations governing the Supplemental Nutrition and Assistance Program (SNAP) require that all states provide employment and training services to SNAP recipients.

Employment First (EF), Colorado’s SNAP Employment and Training Program, helps SNAP applicants and recipients in Colorado connect to meaningful employment and succeed in the pursuit of economic well-being.

EF is a State-supervised, county-administered program. Federal regulations, State statutes, and State rules provide the administrative code of operation for all human service programs in the State, including EF. The Colorado statute outlines the county administration of human services programs and the parameters of State-supervision and county administration (Title 26, C.R.S.).

The State Board of Human Services promulgates the regulations for the EF program; additional guidance is provided through policy, training, and technical assistance.

The EF program is voluntary; there are no mandatory participation requirements. However, federal regulations require some Able-Bodied Adults without Dependents (ABAWD) SNAP recipients to register for work and participate in approved activities to maintain their SNAP eligibility. ABAWD SNAP recipients can meet the participation requirement through EF’s approved employment and training activities.

Colorado county DHS and TPPs are required to submit a plan for program operation to CDHS for review and approval on an annual basis, as outlined in 10 CCR 2506-1 Rule Manual Volume 4.312.1. Plans must adhere to all applicable rules and regulations (such as providing case management and at least one E&T component) and, within those parameters, may be locally tailored based on resources, community needs, and available community partnerships. County DHS and TPP plans are consolidated into a unified EF State plan. County DHS and TPPs are referenced as EF POs when policy and sections within this handbook apply to both County DHS and TPP operators. EF POs receive face-to-face training that provides detailed instructions and examples of common and rare case actions.

Use of Program Operator Handbook

The EF Program Operator Handbook details a standard set of policies and guidelines for delivering and documenting EF program services and expenses. This handbook does not cover every situation or scenario that a provider may encounter in their day-to-day case management activities. This handbook is updated annually, or as needed.

State Employment First Team Directory

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Program Resources

EF POs, community partners, and clients may learn more about Colorado's EF program on our [website](#).

The [EF program partner data dashboards](#) are designed to highlight the important impact of EF POs' work each year. They track how program activities help clients build skills, complete training, earn certificates, and secure lasting employment. Monthly case management data is also included, giving EF POs a clear view of how their program is progressing in meeting key requirements.

General EF program questions can be sent to the DEWS policy inbox at: CDHS_DEWS_Policy_Inbox@state.co.us

Employment First Funding

The EF budget consists of four funding streams, each unique in what it can be used for and when it should be expended. Beginning in July each year, Colorado begins to receive federal allocations to operate the EF Program and passes a majority of the funding to EF POs. In addition to federal funding, Colorado's Long Bill appropriates

\$187,834 for State Program Administration of the EF program and \$78,435 for reimbursements (80/20).

Please note, time spent assisting clients in applying or reapplying for SNAP benefits is not allowable with SNAP E&T funds and cannot be reimbursed.

Funding Stream	Funding Source	Begin Date	End Date
100% Administrative funding	Federal	October 2025	September 2026
50/50 Administrative Reimbursement funding	Federal/EF PO	October 2025	September 2026
50/50 Participant Reimbursement funding	Federal/EF PO	October 2025	September 2026
80/20 Participant Reimbursement funding	Federal/State/EF PO	July 2025	June 2026

Allowable Expenditures by Funding Stream

1. 100% Administrative

100% Administrative funding can be spent during the federal fiscal year (FFY) (October - September). The funding stream consists of federal funds only. 100% Administrative funds are allocated to county human services departments based on the number of work registrants. While not required, it is strongly suggested that counties spend these funds first.

100% Administrative funding can be spent on any allowable purpose in the operation of the EF program, including:

- EF program marketing
- Staffing and overall planning, implementation, and operations
- Direct program expenses, such as:
 - Case management services
 - Administrative functions, such as working on reports and attending training

2. 50/50 Administrative Reimbursement

50/50 Administrative Reimbursement funding can be spent during the FFY (October - September). The funding stream comprises 50 percent federal funds and 50 percent EF PO funds.

50/50 Administrative Reimbursement funding can be spent on any allowable purpose in the operation of the EF program, including:

- EF program marketing

- Staffing and overall planning, implementation, and operations
- Direct program expenses, such as:
 - o Case management services
 - o Administrative functions, such as working on reports and attending training

3. 50/50 Participant Reimbursement

50/50 Participant Reimbursement can be spent during the FFY (October - September). The funding stream comprises 50 percent federal funds and 50 percent EF PO funds.

50/50 Participant Reimbursement funds can be spent on participant expenses that are reasonable, necessary, and directly related to participation in employment and training activities (also known as supportive payments). Please reference the *Supportive Payments* section of this handbook for allowable participant reimbursement expenses.

4. 80/20 Participant Reimbursement

80/20 participant reimbursement funding is available from July to June every year. These participant reimbursement funds are allocated to county human services departments to help partially cover the cost of reimbursing EF clients for necessary expenses tied to program participation. The naming convention of "80/20" represents 50% federal dollars (\$130,725), 30% State dollars (\$78,435), and 20% county dollars (\$52,290).

Employment First Allocation Methodology

Colorado allocates EF funding using different approaches for county human services departments and TPPs.

Historically, Colorado allocated EF funding only to county human services departments. These allocations were based primarily on each county's number of SNAP work registrants, and counties directly provided employment and training services to eligible SNAP applicants and recipients.

In 2019, Colorado expanded its EF funding model to include non-county service providers. Through a competitive bidding process, Colorado began awarding 50/50 Administrative reimbursement funding and 50/50 Participant Reimbursement funding to qualified non-profit, for-profit, and private organizations. These entities, referred to as Third-Party Partners (TPPs), provide employment and training services or have the capacity to do so in coordination with counties. TPPs enhance service delivery by expanding capacity and helping engage additional eligible SNAP work registrants.

For FFY2026, Colorado will continue to allocate EF funding to county human services departments based on the number of SNAP work registrants and the budgets

submitted through the annual EF PO Plan. Counties may receive 100% Administrative funding, 50/50 Administrative funding, 50/50 Participant Reimbursement funding, and 80/20 funding.

TPPs will continue to receive 50/50 Administrative funding and 50/50 Participant Reimbursement funding EF funding through the budgets submitted with annual EF PO plans and, when appropriate, the competitive bid process.

Employment First Partnerships

The EF program funds 16 county DHS and 22 TPPs that generate local partnerships among workforce centers, community colleges, foundations, employers, etc. The focus of each partnership is to enhance wrap-around services and increase the employability upskilling of EF clients.

Partnership with Local SNAP Eligibility Teams

EF POs are required to develop and maintain working relationships with county SNAP eligibility teams. This can be accomplished informally through email, phone calls, or in-person meetings. However, the communication between the EF PO and the county SNAP eligibility team must be documented through detailed case comments in CBMS (date of the communication, communication method, and the result of the communication).

Required communication that must be documented in CBMS includes screening and referrals, regain, and provider determination actions.

Who Is an EF Client?

An EF client is a SNAP applicant or recipient who has been screened by a SNAP eligibility technician to participate in the program, has an active program plan, is enrolled in a program activity, and has been offered supportive payments. An EF client may or may not be subject to the SNAP work requirement. Individuals who are exempt from the SNAP work requirement may still participate in EF if they fall within the populations served by an EF PO.

Colorado's EF program prioritizes serving Able-Bodied Adults without Dependents (ABAWDs). However, EF clients may include other priority populations such as single parents, veterans, and individuals experiencing homelessness. For more information on student eligibility criteria, reference the [SNAP Students and Employment First Memo](#).

To be enrolled and remain engaged in the program, EF clients must be able to participate in program activities for a minimum of 12 hours per month, engage in ongoing case management, and maintain at least monthly contact with their EF worker to report progress toward their employment and self-sufficiency goals.

Able-Bodied Adults without Dependents (ABAWDs)

ABAWDs have a work requirement that requires them to engage in an approved work program (current federally approved work programs are the Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act [WIOA], Veteran Employment and Training programs, and Employment First), work, volunteer, or attend training or school for at least 80 hours a month to receive SNAP benefits. When ABAWDs do not meet their 80-hour work requirement in a month, they may accrue a countable month. When an ABAWD accrues three countable months, they may no longer be eligible for SNAP in a three-year period. As such, ABAWDs must be prioritized in EF recruitment efforts, case management services, and hour/activity tracking in CBMS. This supports ABAWDs in meeting their work requirement and supports ABAWDs' success in the EF program.

EF POs must communicate with SNAP eligibility teams when they become aware of any changes affecting an ABAWD's work requirement or of ABAWD countable months. If an ABAWD does not meet their work requirement but has a reason for not doing so, such as a potential exemption to the work requirement, the EF PO must refer the ABAWD to the SNAP eligibility team to be rescreened.

Recruitment and Engagement

EF POs are responsible for recruiting and engaging SNAP applicants/recipients and providing training and employment opportunities. EF POs need to provide a summary of the EF services available and ensure clients are offered reasonable and necessary supportive payments. EF services and supportive payments must be marketed during all SNAP eligibility interviews. EF POs should effectively develop internal processes to market EF services and supportive payments. EF POs may use the promotional flyer template provided on the [Employment First website](#) and are responsible for amending and maintaining the "For more information" section of the promotional flyer. The "For more information" section of the promotional flyer must contain the EF PO logo, EF PO's contact information, and other relevant information (such as upcoming job fairs and new supportive payments) so SNAP applicants/recipients can contact the EF program to engage with the services offered. (See [SNAP and Employment First Roles and Responsibilities Memo](#))

In addition to the promotional flyer, EF POs may develop additional strategies for general recruitment efforts and recruitment efforts for targeted populations, including but not limited to: ABAWDs, individuals experiencing homelessness, single parents, veterans, students, returning citizens, etc. EF recruitment and engagement strategies may include:

- Building community partnerships and sharing the EF POs promotional flyer at agencies such as:
 - Libraries
 - Technical schools
 - Community colleges
 - Family resource centers
 - Food banks

- Emergency shelters
- Community-based organizations
- Workforce centers
- Developing internal referral processes between EF POs and eligibility teams to ensure successful referrals.
- Collaborate with SNAP Outreach partners and/or subcontractors.

Television and radio broadcasting for the EF program is prohibited and cannot be reimbursed.

Screening and Referrals to Employment First

To ensure consistent implementation of EF services statewide, SNAP eligibility workers and EF POs follow a defined screening and referral process, beginning with the screening conducted by SNAP eligibility workers.

For an effective screening and referral process, EF POs must regularly provide a summary of the services and supportive payments available for SNAP applicants/recipients to all county human services departments in which the EF PO operates.

Screening. Screening is the process used by a SNAP eligibility worker to determine whether an individual should be referred to EF. A SNAP eligibility worker screens for EF by confirming the following criteria:

1. **Age Requirement:** 16-17 years old and the head of household, or 18-64 years old.
2. **Program Availability:** An EF program is operating in the individual's county of residence.
3. **Willing and Able to Participate:** The individual is able and willing to participate in EF services after program expectations and client responsibilities are explained.

Referral. When one or more of the above three screening criteria are met, county SNAP eligibility workers complete a referral to one or more EF POs. Clients who are not interested in EF services can elect to engage with an EF PO at a later date without having to be rescreened by SNAP eligibility.

Screening and Referral Roles and Responsibilities. The county SNAP eligibility team and EF POs each have their own responsibilities when it comes to screening and referrals.

SNAP eligibility workers are responsible for:

- Conducting EF screening.
- Determining whether the individual meets EF referral criteria.
- Informing individuals of:
 - The purpose of the EF program
 - Available EF activities

- Allowable supportive payments
- Program expectations and client responsibilities
- Entering CBMS case comments to document screening and referral actions.
 - The case comment(s) must include two key program actions:
 - 1. The client was screened for the EF program.
 - 2. The client's choice of whether or not to participate in EF.
 - If the client would like to participate in EF, document the referral to the appropriate EF PO in case comments.
 - If the client is unsure, document in case comments and provide the client with EF resources available in the county in which they receive SNAP benefits.
 - If the client declines to participate in EF, document in case comments.

EF POs are responsible for:

- Verifying in CBMS comments that the client was screened by SNAP eligibility using the EF screening criteria before enrolling a client into EF.
- Taking action on referrals within 10 business days of receipt.
 - Action includes contacting the referred individual to schedule an orientation or initial appointment in order to initiate EF services.
- Providing program orientation and explaining:
 - Program mission
 - Available activities
 - Allowable supportive payments
 - Program expectations and client responsibilities
- Regularly providing county human services departments with a summary of available EF services and supportive payments.
- Updating the client's EF Program Status on the Employment First Plan page in CBMS.
- Entering CBMS case comments to document all actions and communication related to EF referrals.
 - All attempts to contact a referred client, including those where the EF PO is unable to reach the client, must be documented in CBMS case comments.

Reverse Referral. At times, a client may meet with an EF PO without first applying for or currently receiving SNAP or being screened for EF. In these cases, the EF PO must notify the client over the phone, in person, or in writing that the client must be directed to SNAP eligibility in order to apply for SNAP and/or be screened for EF. The EF PO has 10 business days to direct the client to a SNAP eligibility team. This is known as a Reverse Referral.

Once the client has applied for SNAP and is screened and referred to EF by a SNAP eligibility team, the EF PO must check CBMS case comments to verify the client has been screened for EF. After these required steps have occurred, the EF PO will follow the regular process of accepting a referral.

Screening and Referral Documentation. EF POs and SNAP eligibility workers are required to enter CBMS case comments to document all steps in the screening and referral process, including all communication.

When an eligibility worker refers a client to EF and the client connects with the EF PO, the EF PO updates the client's EF program status to "EF - Referred" and documents a CBMS case comment.

If an EF PO accepts the referral and the client successfully enrolls in EF, the EF PO updates the client's program status to "EF - Enrolled." However, if the client chooses not to participate in EF, the EF PO keeps the program status as "EF - Referred" and changes the radio button ("Active EF Participant") to "No." Reference the [EF Data Entry Desk Aid](#) and the [Employment First Referral Status Memo](#) for more details.

Finally, the screening and referral process includes multiple steps that, when executed properly, ensure that SNAP and Employment First funding streams are used at different stages of the process. To ensure this occurs, please note that EF POs are not responsible for:

1. Determining exemptions for EF clients, including ABAWDs.
2. Application of discretionary or federal waiver exemptions.
3. Entering or correcting accrued ABAWD countable months.
4. Providing clients with SNAP work requirement rights and responsibilities information.

Provider Determination (PD)

A SNAP applicant/recipient may receive a provider determination (PD) when the EF PO does not offer the activity or service to which the client was referred, does not offer the client's desired supportive payments, or the client does not have the skills required for the activity. For example, an individual is interested in obtaining a Commercial Driver's License (CDL); however, the EF PO only offers training in the healthcare industry. Before making a PD, the EF PO must put forth a good-faith effort to work with the client to consider engaging in other program activities, updating the Individualized Service Plan (ISP), or exploring other supportive payment options that may assist the client.

Within 10 calendar days of making the PD, the EF PO must notify the client that a PD is being made and the reason why. Within the same 10-day period, the EF PO must also inform the local county's SNAP eligibility team of the PD through a phone call, email, or other written communication (such as a form or through a county's work management system) with a brief description of the PD.

Please note that it is a shared responsibility between the EF PO and SNAP eligibility team to develop and document shared business and communication processes to ensure timely and efficient communication when a PD is made. Maintaining a working relationship between the two is essential for timely communication.

All efforts, discussions, and updates related to a PD must also be documented thoroughly in CBMS. Within 10 calendar days of making the PD, the EF PO must close all open EF activities in which the client is enrolled, update the client's program status to "EF-Provider Determination," and entered detailed PD case comments that include:

- The reason the determination was made.
- The date the determination was made.
- The date the client was notified.
- The date the county eligibility team was notified.

An example of an appropriate CBMS case comment is: "Provider Determination made on March 2, 2026 because the EF PO does not offer the bookkeeping training the client needs for employment. Client notified on March 3, 2026 and informed they will be referred back to the county eligibility team for rescreening. County eligibility team notified on March 3, 2026 and referral sent for re-screening."

Please note that EF POs are not responsible for:

- Determining exemptions for EF clients, including ABAWDs.
- Entering or correcting accrued ABAWD countable months.
- Providing EF clients with SNAP rights and responsibilities information.
- Notifying ABAWDs when they receive a countable month or they are subject to receive a countable month.

When a PD is made, the county SNAP eligibility team also has certain responsibilities. Within 10 calendar days of receiving the PD from the EF PO, the eligibility worker must:

1. Contact the client to rescreen them because of the PD.
2. When appropriate, refer the client to another EF PO.

In terms of CBMS data entry, the eligibility worker must ensure that the Work Requirements page has accurate data entered to reflect exemptions (if applicable). This includes "Referred to EF" if the client meets screening criteria and is referred to the program, or "Not Meeting Work Requirements" if the client does not meet screening criteria and is not referred to an EF PO.

In CBMS case comments, the eligibility worker must document:

- The client was referred back to SNAP eligibility due to a PD.
- The date the eligibility worker informed the client of the determination.
- Whether the client continues to meet EF screening criteria.

A PD should only occur when the EF PO truly cannot serve the client. The following situations are **not** PDs and should be handled differently:

1. The client is enrolled in a suitable activity that supports their career goals, but the client does not meet program or activity requirements (such as showing up to workshops, attending case management appointments, or consistently not meeting the program's level of effort).
 - a. **Correct Action:**

- i. Update the ISP to better reflect the client's needs.
 - ii. Create clear, specific, and measurable goals with the client.
 - iii. Document the discussion and plan updates in CBMS case comments.
- b. When a client continues to not meet program or activity requirements after the actions above are taken, the client should be exited from the program with the "EF-Declined Program Services" program status.
 - i. *Reference the [EF Data Entry Desk Aid](#) when updating a client's program status.*
- c. Reminder: a PD should not be used when the issue can be addressed through case management or ISP adjustments.
- 2. The client stops engaging with the program and has not responded to the EF worker for more than 60 days.
 - a. **Correct Action:**
 - i. Document in CBMS case comments that two attempts (via email, phone, or written notification) to re-engage the client within 60 days were unsuccessful.
 - ii. Close the client's activities.*
 - 1. *Reference the [EF Closure Reasons: Not Completed and Unable to Complete Guide](#) when closing activities for an unresponsive client.*
 - 2. **EF POs should only edit their own activities.*
 - iii. Update the client's program status to "EF-Declined Program Services."
 - 1. *Reference the [EF Data Entry Desk Aid](#) when updating a client's program status.*
- 3. An EF worker believes the client may qualify for a work requirement exemption.
 - a. **Correct Action:**
 - i. EF POs do not determine exemptions; however, within five days, the EF PO must:
 - 1. Refer the client to SNAP eligibility staff for rescreening.
 - 2. Document the referral in CBMS case comments.
 - ii. Within 10 days, SNAP Eligibility Staff must then rescreen the client for possible exemptions.
 - 1. If no exemptions apply, the client shall be rescreened for EF.
- 4. An EF PO proactively communicates capacity limits to the county and state EF team.
 - a. **Correct Action:**
 - i. EF POs must *proactively communicate* capacity limits to the county and state EF team.
 - ii. This may include:
 - 1. Informing referral partners that new referrals should not be made.
 - 2. Coordinating with eligibility and referral sources until capacity is available.

- iii. Reminder: program capacity issues should be addressed through communication and referral management and not through PDs.

If an EF PO encounters a scenario in which they are not sure if a PD should be made, please contact your Partner Liaison.

Employment First Program Enrollment

SNAP applicants/recipients will be considered enrolled in EF once a referral has been documented in CBMS by SNAP eligibility, received from the EF PO, and the following steps have been taken:

- The client and EF PO complete a comprehensive employability assessment.
- The client and EF PO develop an ISP based on the results of the comprehensive employability assessment, and the results are entered into CBMS.
- The client and EF PO agree that the client is able to participate in an EF activity (see *Employment First Activities* section for more details), and the activity is reflected on the ISP and entered into CBMS.
- The client is enrolled in case management and at least one allowable EF activity. Clients must participate in at least 12 hours per month across all activities and case management to meet the Level of Effort (LOE) program requirement.
- The EF PO offers or issues the client a reasonable and necessary supportive payment for the client to access the program.

Employment First Program Statuses

EF POs are responsible for updating the client's EF Program Status on the Employment First Plan page in CBMS. See below for all applicable Program Statuses and the appropriate scenario(s) in which to use each status.

- **EF-Referred:** When a client's connection to the EF program results from a referral made by a SNAP eligibility team or another partner agency (after a referral by SNAP eligibility has already occurred).
 - *Note: An EF-Referred client is not yet enrolled in the EF program.*
- **EF-Outreach:** When an EF PO is actively outreaching to engage a client in the EF program.
 - *Note: An EF-Outreach client is not yet enrolled in the EF program.*
- **EF-Enrolled:** When a client has met all of the following criteria:
 - Been screened (and referred, if applicable) by SNAP eligibility to participate in the program,
 - Completed a comprehensive employability assessment (valid for 365 days),
 - Developed an ISP, and it is entered into CBMS* (valid for 120 days),
 - **For a co-enrolled client, see the "Co-Enrollment" section of this handbook for more information and guidance.*
 - Enrolled in and receiving case management,

- Enrolled in at least one allowable EF activity, and
 - *This includes being enrolled in the Job Retention activity.*
- Been offered reasonable and necessary supportive payments to participate in an EF program activity or find employment.
- **Closed:** When a client who was working with EF is no longer eligible for SNAP benefits.
- **EF-Complete:** When an EF-Enrolled client has successfully completed the agreed-upon goals in the ISP and communicates that they no longer need the EF program.
- **EF-Declined Program Services:** When an EF-Enrolled client meets one or more of the following three criteria:
 1. Stops engaging in program participation and/or stops responding to contact attempts by the EF PO.
 - *In these cases, EF POs must conduct the following two actions before ending a client's EF plan with the "EF-Declined Program Services" program status:*
 - *Complete and document in case comments at least **two follow-up attempts** (through email, phone, or written notification) over a 60-day period.*
 - *Note: EF POs can document one hour of case management services for unsuccessful contact attempts.*
 - *If the client does not respond to follow-up attempts, close out the client's activities using the [EF Closure Reasons: Not Completed and Unable to Complete Guide](#).*
 2. Notifies the EF PO that they are no longer interested in EF.
 3. Is enrolled in a suitable activity that supports their career goals, but the client does not meet program or activity requirements, including but not limited to:
 - i. Showing up to required virtual or in-person events like training, workshops, or case management appointments.
 - ii. Not meeting program standards or client conduct expectations.
 - iii. Consistently not meeting the EF program's level of effort.
 - iv. Not progressing in the agreed-upon goals in the ISP.
 - *In these cases, EF POs must conduct the following actions (if possible) before ending a client's EF plan with the "EF-Declined Program Services" program status:*
 - *Update the ISP to better reflect the client's needs.*
 - *Create clear, specific, and measurable goals with the client.*
 - *Document the discussion and plan updates in CBMS case comments.*
- **EF-Provider Determination:** When the EF PO does not offer the activity or service to which the client was referred, does not offer the client's desired supportive payments, or the client does not have the skills required for the activity.

- *In these cases, before making a provider determination (PD), the EF PO must put forth a good-faith effort to work with the client to consider engaging in other program activities, updating the ISP, or exploring other supportive payment options that may assist the client.*
- *If the EF PO truly cannot serve the client, then a PD must be made. Within 10 calendar days of making the PD, the EF PO must:*
 - *Notify the client that a PD is being made and the reason why.*
 - *Inform the local county's SNAP eligibility team of the PD with a brief description of the PD.*

Case Management

EF POs must provide at least one hour of case management services per month to all EF participants, including comprehensive employability assessments, ISPs, progress monitoring, coordination with service providers, and reassessments. EF PO workers must meet with clients individually or in a group setting. This can occur in person, virtually, over the phone, or via email. All case management hours must be documented on the Attendance tab in CBMS.

CBMS must be used as the system of record for all case management services and documentation. All forms of case management, screening and referral, enrollment, attendance hours, and communication with the client must be documented in CBMS within 14 days of service delivery, and no later than the 6th of the following month.

Time spent in case management services can be rounded up to one hour (or more if applicable). For example, if an EF PO worker and client had a scheduled appointment for an hour but only met for 45 minutes to update an ISP, the EF PO worker may round up and document one hour of case management in CBMS.

Case comments must document all program activities, including how the client was introduced or onboarded to the program (such as attending an orientation or 1:1 initial appointment). EF POs are also required to retain supporting documentation in a client's case file, including but not limited to the following:

- A signed copy of the comprehensive employability assessment (client and EF PO worker signature, verbal acknowledgment, or electronic confirmation documented in case comments).
- A signed copy of the ISP (client and EF PO worker signature, verbal acknowledgment, or electronic confirmation documented in case comments).
- Any documentation that supports why the client is placed in an EF program activity.

Comprehensive employability assessments must be conducted at the initial case management appointment and at least once every 365 days. The comprehensive assessment must also be signed by both the client and EF PO worker and be retained in the client's case file. The comprehensive employability assessment must assess at least one of the following:

- applied academic skills

- interpersonal skills
- critical thinking skills
- communication skills
- challenges to access employment

Please refer to your organization's approved EF PO Plan for the comprehensive employability assessment approved for use during this program year. If the EF PO does not have an approved employability assessment, they may use the State's [Employment First Employability Assessment](#) or the [Spanish Employment First Employability Assessment](#).

Individualized Service Plans are individualized to the client, developed in partnership (in-person or virtually) between the client and EF PO worker, updated at least once every 120 days, and must be retained in the client's case file and added to the client's "Employment First Plan" page in CBMS. ISPs must include:

- Measurable, specific short-term and long-term goals that focus on employment, training, and/or education.
- Allowable EF activities that align with short-term and long-term goals.
- Specific client and EF PO worker action items during the 120-day period of the ISP.
- Signatures (physical signature, verbal acknowledgment from the client and EF PO worker with a corresponding case comment, or electronic confirmation such as an email) from both the client and EF PO worker.
- Coordination with and referrals to other employment and training service providers, when applicable, and can include:
 - Referrals to WIOA, Vocational Rehabilitation, Veteran Services, or any other Title I Employment and Training programs.
 - Referrals to community colleges or any other Title II Education program.
 - Education of and referral to appropriate community resources (e.g., food banks, clothing providers, mental health providers, housing providers, etc.).
 - Collaboration with community partners through periodic meetings and communication.

ISPs must be updated at least every 120 days or when the client's goals or planned activities change.

Progress monitoring check-ins must include a case comment, even if the progress monitoring check-in is an attempt to follow up with the client. Progress monitoring case comments must be documented in CBMS at least once a month (monthly meetings held virtually or in-person, phone calls, correspondence via email, or attempted contacts to re-engage a client).

A detailed case comment must include:

- The date that the communication, attempted contact, or meeting/action (referral, outreach, ISP, progress monitoring, coordination with other service providers, supportive payments, and job retention service) was conducted.

- A summary of the case management meeting; client's progress in the EF activities in which they are enrolled; and any goals, barriers, and challenges completed/identified for the EF client.
- Resources (approved volunteer sites, clothing, informational flyers) provided or offered during the case management meeting.
- Supportive payments offered (and if they were issued or denied) during the case management meeting, including why the supportive payment was reasonable and necessary to participate in the program (see the *Supportive Payments* section for more details).
- Any referrals made to other service providers during the case management meeting on behalf of the client. Examples include:
 - Community resources, higher education, or public transportation.
- Next steps, including but not limited to: the next appointment date and time for the EF PO worker and the EF client to meet, and any new objectives/goals for the worker and client.

Below is a blank case comment template that encompasses all required aspects of a detailed progress monitoring case comment, which EF PO workers may find useful:

1. **Date of Meeting:**
2. **Summary (Activity Progress/Goals/Barriers):**
3. **Resources Provided (Clothing, Flyers, etc.):**
4. **Supportive Payments Offered/Issued/Denied (and Reasoning):**
5. **Referrals to Other Service Providers:**
6. **Next Steps (Next Appt., and New Objectives/Goals):**

A progress monitoring case comment, even if the progress monitoring is an attempt to follow up with the client, must be documented in CBMS at least once a month.

Co-Enrollment

EF POs offer unique service delivery models that, when paired with another EF PO, provide effective wraparound support for SNAP recipients. This section guides EF POs on how to effectively co-enroll clients and work collaboratively to support clients in meeting their employment goals.

Types of Co-Enrolled Clients. A client may sometimes seek services or support that are not offered by their current EF PO but are available through another one. Currently, there are existing co-enrolled clients and those who want to become new co-enrolled clients.

For existing co-enrolled clients, EF POs are required to routinely review CBMS for signs of a client already receiving services from another EF PO. This includes checking ISPs, case comments, and EF activities.

When an individual is interested in becoming a new co-enrolled client, the EF worker must review the situation with the client and discuss whether co-enrollment with two

EF POs would be beneficial for providing wraparound support to meet their employment needs and goals.

Co-Enrollment Policy Requirements. Whether a client is identified as already co-enrolled in CBMS or is determined to benefit from new co-enrollment, both EF POs must adhere to the policy guidelines detailed in this section. **Both EF POs will work together to:**

1. Determine within five business days of identifying an existing or new co-enrolled client who will become the Lead EF PO and the Supporting EF PO.
 - a. EF POs are responsible for initiating communication with one another regarding a co-enrolled client. Contact details for EF POs are available on the [Employment First Partners by County List](#).
 - b. EF POs must schedule an initial meeting with each other to determine who will be the Lead EF PO and Supporting EF PO.
 - i. The State EF team recommends that the initial meeting takes place within 10 days.
 - c. Then, the EF POs must schedule a joint meeting with their shared client to explain co-enrollment and how they will work together to provide wraparound support.
2. Add a case comment in CBMS that explains how they will work together to support the client.
 - a. Example: “Partner A and Partner B met on 3/5/26 to discuss co-enrollment for our shared client. Partner A will provide work-based learning (WBL) to help the client pursue a career in the restaurant industry, and Partner B will support the client in obtaining their General Equivalency Diploma (GED). Partner A and Partner B will meet with the client regularly to check in on their goals and progress. Partner A will provide transportation and supportive payments as the client does not have reliable transportation.”
3. Determine a meeting cadence to review and discuss the client’s progress and to avoid duplication of services. If a client’s goals and/or activities change, EF POs must work together to update the ISP accordingly.
 - a. Please note that the Supporting EF PO must not overwrite the existing ISP in CBMS.
4. Document any changes to the support being provided to the client in CBMS case comments following progress monitoring requirements (see the *Case Management* section of this handbook).

EF Co-Enrollment Responsibilities	Lead EF PO	Supporting EF PO
Complete Comprehensive Employability Assessment with client* <i>*The client must complete a separate Comprehensive Employability Assessment with each EF PO</i>	☒	☒
Complete Individualized Service Plan (ISP)* with client <i>*The Lead EF PO is responsible for updating the ISP on the “Employment First Plan” page CBMS and coordinating with the Supporting EF PO in developing the</i>	☒	☐

EF Co-Enrollment Responsibilities	Lead EF PO	Supporting EF PO
<i>ISP. The ISP in CBMS should include the goals and activities established by both EF POs.</i>		
Participate in an initial meeting to determine which partner will be the Lead and Supporting EF PO	☒	☒
Communicate with the client that they are receiving services from two EF POs	☒	☒
Provide case management* services <i>*Both EF POs must open and maintain separate case management activities in CBMS</i>	☒	☒
Create and maintain allowable EF activities in CBMS that are specific to each EF PO	☒	☒
Enter case comments and attendance hours into CBMS by the 6th of each month for the previous month for any meetings/activities that occurred	☒	☒
Create and maintain any <i>Activities for Work Requirement</i> (In-Kind/Volunteer Work, Paid Work, Qualifying Work Program, or Unpaid Work) in CBMS, if an ABAWD is meeting their work requirement by participating in activities outside of EF	☒	☐
Ensure ABAWD clients have at least 80 hours entered in CBMS across all activities by the Notice of Action (NOA) cutoff (see the <i>Activity Hour Data Entry</i> section for more details)	☒	☐
Ensure clients are offered supportive payments and enter into CBMS* <i>*Both the Lead EF PO and Supporting EF PO must complete this action if supportive payments are provided</i>	☒	☒
Enter attendance hours to ensure all clients, regardless of ABAWD/non-ABAWD status, are meeting the EF LOE (12 hours across all activities and case management)	☒	☒
Communicate with SNAP eligibility (when applicable)* <i>*The Lead EF PO must include the Supporting EF PO in any communication</i>	☒	☐

Co-Enrollment and Level of Effort. EF POs must collaborate to ensure co-enrolled clients meet the LOE requirement for the EF program. Both the Supporting and Lead EF PO are responsible for entering hours in the CBMS Attendance Screen.

Example: A co-enrolled client is pursuing their GED with support from Partner A, participating in WBL with Partner B, and receiving case management from both Partner A and Partner B. See the table below for how this client could meet the LOE requirement by being co-enrolled with both EF POs.

Activities	Partner A Hours <i>Lead EF PO</i>	Partner B Hours <i>Supporting EF PO</i>
Case Management	2	1
WBL	N/A	8
GED	5	N/A
Total	7	9
Combined Monthly Total	16	

In the example above, the co-enrolled client will not meet the LOE working with only one partner or the other; however, when the services are combined between the two EF POs, the client meets the LOE requirement by engaging in a combination of 16 hours of case management and other EF activities.

Co-Enrollment and SNAP ABAWD Work Requirement. EF POs must collaborate to ensure ABAWDs are not only meeting the level of effort ***but are engaged for at least 80 hours*** in a combination of the following: case management, time spent in activities with either EF PO, or time spent in a work activity outside of EF (In-Kind/Volunteer Work, Paid Work, Qualifying Work Program, or Unpaid Work).

Example: A co-enrolled client is pursuing their GED with support from Partner A, participating in WBL with Partner B, receiving case management from both Partner A and Partner B, and works part-time for 18 hours a week (72 hours a month). See the table below for how this client could meet the SNAP ABAWD work requirement by being co-enrolled with both EF POs.

Activities	Partner A Hours <i>Lead EF PO</i>	Partner B Hours <i>Supporting EF PO</i>
Case Management	2	1
WBL	N/A	8
GED	5	N/A
Paid Work	72	N/A
Total	79	9
Combined Monthly Total	88	

In the example above, the co-enrolled client meets the LOE by working with Partner A and Partner B. The client is also working 72 hours per month outside of EF. When Partner A enters the client's Paid Work hours in CBMS, the client is meeting both the

LOE and SNAP ABAWD work requirement by engaging in a total of 88 hours of EF program and work activities.

Co-Enrollment Data Entry Requirements. Any action that falls under an EF PO's duties (listed in the *EF Co-Enrollment Responsibilities* table above) must be recorded as a case comment in CBMS by the 6th of the following month. For example, the Lead EF PO must add a case comment when they tell a client that they will also be working with another EF PO and confirm that the client understands they will receive shared services, support, and meetings (when appropriate).

Co-Enrollment Document Retention. Both EF POs are required to adhere to the document retention policy detailed in the *Record Retention* section of this handbook.

Supportive Payments (Participant Reimbursements)

EF POs are required to offer to pay for or reimburse SNAP applicants/recipients for all expenses that are reasonable, necessary, and directly related to participation in the EF program and in finding employment. Federal regulations refer to these expenses as participant reimbursements, but the EF program calls them supportive payments.

These payments are program-funded and can be issued to clients before the initial EF meeting so that the client may begin engaging in program services.

The EF program authorizes the use of multiple types of supportive payments to assist clients in overcoming barriers to employment, such as transportation assistance, rental assistance, tuition, course fees, and work clothing. These supportive payments are identified in each year's State SNAP Employment and Training Plan and reflected in each EF PO's annually approved EF PO Plan. EF POs may only offer supportive payments listed in their approved EF PO Plan, and all supportive payments paid for in the FFY must be issued in the same FFY.

Client Notification Requirements. Clients must be informed that supportive payments are available to help them engage and succeed in the EF program and in finding employment. This information must be communicated at multiple points throughout participation, including:

- During the SNAP eligibility and redetermination appointment with eligibility workers.
- At the initial EF case management appointment or program orientation.
- During all ongoing EF program meetings and progress monitoring check-ins.

EF POs must also ensure that clients understand:

- The types of supportive payments that may be available.
- The purpose of the payment is to support participation and employment goals.
- That clients may be required to provide supporting documentation to verify that the supportive payment was spent as intended (receipt, rental agreement, etc.).

Reasonable and Necessary Supportive Payments. An allowable supportive payment is considered "reasonable and necessary" if it's the kind of expense a prudent person in similar circumstances would spend and is directly related to the client's participation in the EF program. That is:

- It directly supports the client's ability to participate in EF activities reflected in their ISP.
- It is what someone would normally pay in the same situation.
- The cost is in line with similar program expenses.
- It is an allowable expense reflected in the EF PO's annual plan and EF State Plan.
- It is not an ongoing expense, but instead, is used to help a client stabilize and engage in EF and is reasonable and necessary to participate in the program.

All issued supportive payments must have a case comment explaining how the supportive payment is reasonable and necessary for the individual to participate in the EF program.

If you are not sure if a requested supportive payment is reasonable and necessary, please contact your Partner Liaison to discuss the request prior to issuing the payment.

Supportive Payment Documentation. Documentation must clearly demonstrate the supportive payment's purpose and direct link to the client's EF activity or employment goal.

Documentation must also include:

- the client's name
- type of payment
- amount of the payment to whom the service was paid
- receipt of the payment
- date that the supportive payment was provided, and, if applicable, date that the supportive payment was paid

EF POs must record all documentation information, including method of disbursement, in CBMS case comments and on the CBMS (Inside or Outside) Supportive Payments screen to ensure accurate tracking of expenditures within the EF program.

- Inside Supportive Payments tab: For payments issued to a client's EBT card.
- Outside Supportive Payments tab: For payments issued outside of a client's EBT card.

EF POs must also retain documentation of receipt, such as client acknowledgment in case comments, vendor invoice, or proof of purchase, to verify that the supportive payment was provided and received.

- If using a receipt form ([Resource K](#)) to document that the client received the supportive payment, the receipt form should:
 - Be signed by both the client and the staff member of the organization

- Include the client's 1B number
- Include the type of supportive payment provided and its value/cost
- For supportive payments issued on an EBT card, a verbal confirmation from the client with a case comment meets the requirement of documentation.

See the Supportive Payment Documentation Examples ([Resource T](#)) for more information.

Allowable Supportive Payment Disbursement Methods. Supportive payments may be issued using any of the following allowable disbursement methods:

Documented on CBMS <u>Inside</u> Supportive Payments tab	Documented on CBMS <u>Outside</u> Supportive Payments tab
● Client's EBT card	● Gift cards (e.g., for transportation, work clothing, or supplies) ● Vouchers redeemable for specific goods or services ● Direct payment to vendors (e.g., employers, landlords, or training providers)

EF POs must ensure that all disbursement methods align with their internal fiscal procedures. If an EF PO needs to use an alternative disbursement method that is not listed above, please contact your Partner Liaison for approval.

Supportive Payment Limits. Supportive payment costs must not exceed the maximum amount established in each EF PO's approved EF PO Plan. These limits ensure consistency, fiscal accountability, and alignment with the funding available to each EF PO.

If a supportive payment exceeds the cost limit listed in the EF PO Plan, it must receive prior written approval from the EF PO Director or Designee before the payment is issued. Documentation of this approval must be maintained in the client's case file and fiscal records.

Missing Verification or Receipts. Verification that a client received a supportive payment is considered "missing" when a monetary value is exchanged for goods and/or services and a receipt or acknowledgment was requested but failed to be returned. If a client fails to submit a receipt, EF POs must document the attempts in CBMS case comments to encourage the client to return the receipt or acknowledge receipt of the supportive payment.

Incentives and Stipends. Incentives and stipends are not allowable expenditures under the EF program. This means that EF POs **cannot** issue payments to clients as a reward for completing an activity, internship, or training component.

Employment First Job Retention

EF POs must offer job retention services to clients who secure employment (a new job or promotion within their existing job) after enrolling and participating in the EF program. Job retention services are available even after a client's SNAP case has closed due to income.

Please note, there are times when an individual is leaving SNAP due to a failure to comply with the general work requirement or an intentional program violation. In these instances, the client cannot receive job retention services, even if they secured employment after enrolling and participating in EF.

Job retention services include job coaching and assistance that support resolving any barriers that may affect employment. Clients may also receive supportive payments for necessary expenses directly related to job retention, such as clothing required for work, job-related equipment or tools, transportation, and child care.

Clients enrolled in the Job Retention activity are required to complete a minimum of one hour per month in job retention services and one hour per month in case management to meet the LOE program requirement. This specific LOE is only applicable to clients enrolled in the Job Retention activity.

EF POs are expected to make a good-faith effort to offer at least 30 days of job retention services to eligible clients. This includes informing clients about the 30-day minimum requirement, opening a Job Retention activity in CBMS, and developing a Job Retention ISP in CBMS that extends for at least 30 days.

Note: There is no limit to the number of times an individual may receive job retention services, as long as the individual has re-enrolled and participated with the EF Program before obtaining new employment.

For a visual aid with information on determining when a client can receive job retention services, for how long, and how to navigate this in CBMS, see the Job Retention Decision Tree ([Resource R](#)).

Activity Hour Data Entry

EF POs must track and enter all activity hours completed by clients into CBMS. Activity hours must be entered by the 6th of each month for the previous month.

Level of Effort. All EF clients are required to complete a minimum of 12 hours per month, which must be tracked and entered in the CBMS Attendance screen, in case management and at least one EF allowable activity. This requirement is referred to as Level of Effort (LOE). All EF clients, including ABAWDs, are required to meet this 12-hour LOE each month.

During a client's first month in the EF program, the EF PO must support the client in working toward the LOE requirement. By the second month and beyond, the EF PO must ensure that the client is meeting the LOE.

Moreover, the LOE hour minimum is adjusted for clients enrolled in the Job Retention activity. These clients must complete at least one hour per month in job retention services and one hour per month in case management.

When a client cannot meet the LOE, EF POs must document in CBMS case comments the challenges faced by the client that led to them being unable to complete this EF program requirement. Any exceptions for not meeting the LOE should be rare and only considered for extenuating circumstances.

SNAP ABAWD Work Requirement. ABAWDs can maintain their SNAP benefits by working, training, or volunteering for at least 80 hours per month. This can include paid work, unpaid work (volunteering), participation in Colorado's Employment First program, or participation in another employment and training program.

The hours from the LOE requirement of at least 12 hours per month in case management and at least one EF allowable activity count toward the SNAP ABAWD work requirement.

- For example, in one month, if a client completes one hour of case management, 11 hours of Adult Basic Education, and 68 hours of part-time job, then this client has met both the 12-hour LOE and 80-hour SNAP ABAWD work requirement.

When an ABAWD is meeting their work requirement through a combination of EF activities and their own work efforts outside of EF, EF POs must open *Activities for Work Requirement* in CBMS, along with any existing allowable EF activities in which the ABAWD is participating. EF POs are responsible for entering attendance hours for *Activities for Work Requirement* whenever a client is an ABAWD.

Activities for Work Requirement include:

- **In-Kind/Volunteer Work:** When your client works for an individual or entity for goods or services (for something other than money) OR volunteers their time and/or labor for an entity, either for an event or on an ongoing basis. This is for in-kind/volunteer work where wages are not expected.
 - The [Volunteer Verification Form](#) must be completed by the organization or individual for whom the client is volunteering and then submitted by the client to the EF PO. The EF PO must store the completed form in the client's case file.
- **Paid Work:** When your client works for an individual or entity for a wage or salary.
- **Qualifying Work Program:** When your client is participating in a qualifying work program other than SNAP E&T (Employment First) or Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF), also known as Colorado Works (CW). Examples of a qualifying work program include:

- Workforce Innovation & Opportunity Act (WIOA)
- Trade Adjustment Assistance (TAA)
- Veteran Programs
- **Unpaid Work:** When your client works for an individual without the exchange of a wage, salary, goods, or services. An example of unpaid work is an unpaid internship or apprenticeship that is not associated with the EF program.

11/9 Rule. All EF activities count toward the SNAP ABAWD Work Requirement. Supervised Job Search (SJS) may be included as part of those hours, as long as it makes up less than half of the 80 required hours in a month. This is known as the 11/9 Rule.

What to Do When SNAP ABAWD Work Requirement Hours are Incomplete. At times, an ABAWD client may be unable to meet their 80-hour work requirement, whether it is from an extenuating circumstance or the client failed to complete or submit hours to their EF PO worker during the month. EF POs must notify the client and document this in a CBMS case comment.

An example of an appropriate CBMS case comment is: “Client was unable to meet their 80-hour SNAP ABAWD Work Requirement for the month of February due to losing access to transportation. Notified the client via email that these hours are incomplete for the month.”

Notice of Action (NOA). NOA is the cutoff date (approximately the 18th of the month) in CBMS to notify a household of a loss or reduction of SNAP benefits due to three countable months. This is important for the EF program because if an ABAWD does not meet the SNAP ABAWD work requirement, they can receive a countable month. After three countable months, the ABAWD may lose SNAP benefits.

Accurate and timely data entry by EF POs is crucial and can prevent an ABAWD from receiving a NOA and a countable month.

Starting April 2026, to the best of their ability, EF POs must enter ABAWD activity participation hours by the 18th of the current month to reduce the chance that an ABAWD will receive a countable month. If hours are entered after the 18th of the month, the EF PO must contact the SNAP eligibility office where the client receives benefits to ensure the ABAWD does not accrue a countable month. A SNAP eligibility technician can reverse a countable month when appropriate.

Why It Is Important to Report Work Requirement Hours. Failure to enter hours in a timely manner can put an ABAWD client at risk of losing their SNAP benefits. If any extenuating circumstances prevent activity hour entry, EF POs must communicate with the appropriate county’s SNAP eligibility team immediately and then document in CBMS case comments. EF POs must document any late data entry or when a client does not report activity hours in a timely manner.

Employment First Activities

All EF clients must be enrolled in case management and at least one allowable EF activity, which are defined below.

1. Case Management

- a. Meet with clients (individually or in a group setting) as they engage in the EF program. This can occur in person, virtually, over the phone, or via email. All EF clients must receive at least one hour per month of case management. These services include comprehensive employability assessments conducted at least annually, ISPs updated at least once every 120 days, monthly progress monitoring, and coordination with and referrals to other service providers.
- b. Please note that case management alone is not considered an allowable EF activity. EF clients must be enrolled in both case management **and** an allowable EF activity.

2. Adult Basic Education

- a. Pre-GED basic skills education for clients who test between 5.5 and 8.5-grade level to increase skill level and attain a GED. Homework may also be assigned and counted for participation hours.

3. Career and/or Technical Education (CTE) and Vocational Training

- a. Skills training related to a specific occupation, such as welding, word processing, auto mechanics, truck driving school, or data entry.

4. Employability

- a. Classes or individual instruction to help a client become work-ready. Employability encompasses work readiness skills, including cognitive skills like reading for information, applied math, and problem solving. It also includes soft skills training that enhances an individual's interactions, job performance, and career prospects, such as team building and workplace discipline. Instruction may also include, but is not limited to, improving communication skills, receiving customer service training, and GED preparation. Clients must follow a curriculum that targets work readiness.
- b. *Note: If a client is enrolled in Employability, case comments must demonstrate that the client is following a curriculum or series.*

5. English as a Second Language (ESL)

- a. English language classes for clients whose primary language is not English and whose lack of English language skills presents a barrier to employment.

6. General Equivalency Diploma (GED)

- a. Preparation and/or testing for the GED or equivalent.

7. Job Retention

- a. EF POs must offer job retention services, for a minimum of 30 days but no more than 365 days from the opened activity's start date, to clients who secure employment after enrolling in the EF program.
- b. Job retention services include job coaching and assistance with resolving any issues that may affect employment. These services are available even after a client's SNAP case has closed, unless the individual is leaving SNAP due to a failure to comply with the general work

requirement or an intentional program violation. Clients may also receive supportive payments for necessary expenses directly related to job retention.

- c. *Note: Due to a federal waiver, job retention services can be provided up to 365 days through September 30, 2026. Without a federal waiver, the maximum limit for services is 90 days.*

8. Literary Instruction

- a. Basic literary education for clients who test at or below the 5.5-grade level. Homework may also be assigned and counted for participation hours.

9. Post-Secondary Education

- a. Placement or continuation in post-secondary education opportunities for clients who are enrolled and working towards a degree.

10. Self-Employment Classes

- a. Self-employment instruction for clients who are interested in learning how to start or enhance their own business.

11. Supervised Job Search (SJS)

- a. A supervised set of activities directly linked to increasing the client's employment opportunities, including, but not limited to: assignments, measurable steps for the client, resume reviews, interview practice, supported job research, or job searching skills. Supervision can occur remotely or in-person and must include meeting with the client one-on-one or in a group setting at least once a month to provide meaningful guidance, troubleshoot job search issues, and instruct clients to set measurable goals that lead to employment for the client.

- i. *Note: Clients turning in job contacts to an EF PO worker without meaningful guidance and measurable goals tracked in case comments do not qualify as SJS.*

- b. In-person SJS must be conducted at a State-approved location, which involves having access to computers, internet, or publicly available Wi-fi. EF POs must also provide necessary supportive payments and be able to track client participation in the SJS activity. Any supportive payments provided, SJS participation hours, and case management meetings must be documented in CBMS.

- c. *Note: If a client is enrolled in SJS, case comments must demonstrate how the SJS activity is supervised.*

Work-based Learning Activities:

Please note that when opening any work-based learning (WBL) activity on the Maintain Participant Activities screen in CBMS, there are certain fields under the Employment Detail section that become required. These required fields include:

- Employer Name
- Hourly Wage
- Monthly Wage
 - Use this formula to calculate a client's **estimated** monthly wage:
"Hourly Wage × Hours Worked Per Week × 52/12 = Monthly Wage"
 - ex: \$18.00 × 32 × 52/12 = \$2,496.00

- Use this formula to calculate a client's ***estimated*** monthly wage for clients who receive tips in addition to their hourly wage:

$$“(Hourly Wage + Hourly Tip Rate*) \times Hours Worked Per Week \times 52/12 = Monthly Wage”$$
 - ex: $(\$19.00 + \$11.50) \times 32 \times 52/12 = \$4,229.33$
 - **To calculate “Hourly Tip Rate,” divide the client’s total tips by the total hours worked.*
- Job Code (related to Standard Occupation Codes)
- Job Title (related to Standard Occupation Codes)
- 12. **Work-based Learning, Internship, Unsubsidized or Subsidized (WBLI)**
 - a. An internship is a short-term, hands-on, supervised work experience with a professional organization that acts as an extension of the classroom. The experience must include intentional, clear learning objectives; defined start and end dates; a job description; training to develop transferable skills or knowledge; quality supervision with routine feedback to guide and mentor the intern; and resources to support learning objectives.
- 13. **Work-based Learning, On-the-Job Training, Unsubsidized (WBLOJT)**
 - a. OJT is training by an employer in a real-world or classroom setting that is provided to a paid participant. The participant should be engaged in productive, in-depth work that provides knowledge or skills essential to the job/career field, is limited in duration, and aligns with a set curriculum. OJT emphasizes employer engagement, includes specific training objectives, and leads to regular employment.
- 14. **Work-based Learning, Pre-apprenticeships, Unsubsidized or Subsidized (WBLPA)**
 - a. A pre-apprenticeship program is designed to prepare individuals to enter and succeed in an apprenticeship program (*see activity 15*).
- 15. **Work-based Learning, Apprenticeships, Unsubsidized or Subsidized (WBLPA — this is currently the same coding as Pre-apprenticeships in CBMS)**
 - a. An apprenticeship program is a work-based training program that includes an OJT activity (*see activity 13*) and related technical instruction, which provides classroom-style learning to support the OJT and enhance the skills needed for the job. Instruction can be provided by a community college, technical school, apprenticeship training school, or the employer. It can take place in a classroom setting, online, or directly at the work site. Similar to OJT, pre-apprenticeships and apprenticeships are sustained interactions with professionals that follow a set curriculum and foster in-depth, firsthand engagement with the tasks required in a given career field. Pre-apprenticeships and apprenticeships emphasize employer engagement, include specific training objectives, and lead to regular employment.
- 16. **Work-based Learning, Transitional Jobs, Unsubsidized or Subsidized (WBLTJ)**
 - a. Transitional jobs are time-limited, paid work experiences that can be offered as individualized career services by local workforce development boards under WIOA. Subsidized up to 100 percent, these jobs can be in

the public, private, or nonprofit sectors. They are only available to individuals with barriers to employment, such as chronic unemployment or inconsistent work histories. Transitional jobs provide participants with work experience and essential workplace skills, with the program provider generally acting as the employer.

17. Workfare

- a. Workfare is a structured, time-limited volunteer placement designed for EF clients. The goal is to help clients gain valuable work experience, increase their employability, and support their transition into long-term, sustainable employment. Workfare placements are to be agreed upon between a workfare site, EF PO, and the client. They must occur at a public or private non-profit organization and cannot exceed specific lengths of time (defined in each workfare path below).
- b. All workfare sites must have a Workfare Site Agreement, and clients placed at a workfare site must have a Workfare Client Agreement.
- c. All workfare site activities, hours, the steps taken to place a client in the workfare site, and the client's outcome after participating in workfare must be documented in CBMS.
 - i. *The number of hours a client is expected to participate in workfare each month is calculated by dividing the total household monthly SNAP benefit amount by the current Colorado minimum wage. See the [EF Workfare Toolkit](#) for additional details on workfare and the requirements.*
 - ii. *Note: Fractions of hours are always rounded down.*
 1. *Example: If a household receives \$500 in SNAP benefits and the Colorado minimum wage is \$15.16, then: $\$500 / \$15.16 = 32.98$, round down to 32 hours/month or 8 hours/week*
- d. CDHS offers three paths for clients after selecting the workfare activity in CBMS:
 - i. **Workfare Interim Activity:** A placeholder volunteer activity from the State-approved workfare list or one that has been approved by the State for clients who are preparing for employment, Workfare Job Path, Workfare Placement, or another allowable EF activity. A client cannot be in a Workfare Interim Activity for longer than 30 days.
 - ii. **Workfare Job Path:** Clients are participating in a 30-day supervised job search activity, after which they can continue in Workfare Placement or another allowable EF activity.
 - iii. **Workfare Placement:** A long-term workfare site placement, which is not to exceed 12 months.
- e. *Note: If a client is enrolled in Workfare, case comments must demonstrate the path in which the client is engaged.*

Billing Procedures

County DHS receive a variety of E&T funding streams, including 100 percent, 50/50 percent, and 80/20 percent. County funding, foundational funding, and donations from private firms or non-profit organizations are appropriate sources for the county DHS's share of the 50/50 and 80/20 E&T funding. The county DHS share of E&T funding cannot be from a federal source.

County DHS are responsible for submitting all EF program expenses through the CFMS. CFMS codes and the order in which a county DHS should spend down Employment First funding can be found in the tables below.

Employment First Administrative Funding			
Funding Source	Allowable Expenses	CFMS Code	Recommend Order of Spending in FFY26
100% Administrative Funding	Any allowable program expenditure, except participant reimbursement. Subsidized employment wages and stipends may be charged to this funding stream.	F700.6150	1st - a 50% match is not needed to draw down this funding stream. This funding stream must be spent by September 30, 2026.
50/50 Administrative Reimbursement Funding	Any allowable program expenditure, except participant reimbursement. Subsidized employment wages and stipends may be charged to this funding stream.	F750.6300	2nd - A 50% match by the county or contractor is needed to pull down the 50% federal funding match. This funding stream must be spent by September 30, 2026.

Employment First Participant Reimbursement Funding			
Funding Source	Allowable Expenses	CFMS Code	Recommend Order of Spending in FFY26
80/20 Participant Reimbursement Funding	Any allowable, reasonable, and necessary cost to a client associated with the participation in Employment First. Reference your County's Employment First Plan or the State Employment First Plan for examples of allowable participant reimbursements. This funding stream is comprised of 30% State General Funds 20% County Funds	F800.6375	1st - only a 20% county or contractor match is needed to draw down this funding stream. This funding stream must be spent by June 30, 2026.

	50% Federal Funds		
50/50 Participant Reimbursement Funding	Any allowable, reasonable, and necessary cost to a client associated with the participation in Employment First. Reference your County's Employment First Plan or the State Employment First Plan for examples of allowable participant reimbursements.	F750.6305	2nd - A 50% match by the county or contractor is needed to draw down the 50% federal funding match. This funding stream must be spent by September 30, 2026.

Third-Party Partner Billing Procedures

TPPs' main sources of funding include 50/50 Administrative and 50/50 Participant Reimbursement. TPPs must fund and provide EF services, and submit documentation and an invoice to receive up to 50 percent reimbursement for the cost of the services provided. General state funds, foundational funding, and donations from private firms or non-profit organizations are appropriate sources of non-federal funds for the TPP's draw-down of the federal E&T funding.

TPPs are responsible for following the invoice submission process outlined below and in the Statement of Work. TPPs must send monthly invoices, ledgers, and required supporting documentation via encrypted email to the assigned State EF team member. Required supporting documentation includes the TPP Caseload - Final report and Outside Supportive Services report. These two reports must be filtered to only show the specific TPP's clients and the data for the month in which services were rendered.

These documents are due by the 15th of each month (for services rendered in the previous month), unless otherwise requested by CDHS. Please note that due to the CDHS Accounting timeline, the June invoice is due by June 30th. If the specified days do not fall on a business day, then invoices, ledgers, and required supporting documentation will be due on the next business day.

If a TPP does not plan to submit an invoice, the TPP must inform CDHS in writing by the 15th of the month. If a TPP needs an extension to submit their monthly invoice, the TPP must seek written approval from CDHS prior to their submission deadline.

If CDHS does not receive a TPP's invoice within 30 days of the invoice's due date, the TPP may forfeit their reimbursement at CDHS's discretion. Failure to submit invoices, ledgers, and required supporting documentation, or request for extensions in a timely manner, could result in delayed or denial of invoice payment, and denial of a contract extension for the next program year.

To ensure reimbursement of allowable services and expenses, the TPP must:

1. Ensure that all SNAP applicants/recipients on invoice documentation either received SNAP benefits or applied for SNAP benefits in the same month that the service(s) were provided by the TPP.
2. Ensure that all activities and supportive payments listed on documentation are delivered in the same month that reimbursement is being requested.
3. Ensure that all activities and supportive payments align with the activities and supportive payments defined in their approved Program Operator Plan.
4. Ensure all data entry in CBMS is complete, accurate, and in adherence to the guidance provided in this handbook for all clients listed on documentation.
5. Ensure all supporting documentation for services provided to clients is complete, accurate, and in adherence to the guidance provided in this handbook.

TPPs are required to retain supporting documentation that supports program deliverables for a four-year period (including the current contract period). Supporting documentation may include, but not be limited to: invoices, receipts for goods provided to clients, timesheets with signatures for workshops that clients attend, travel receipts for internal staff, client case files (both physical and electronic records), and records with signatures demonstrating time spent on client services, etc. TPPs must provide supporting documentation within three business days upon request.

The State EF team member will have five business days to review the submitted invoice, ledger, and required supporting documentation and will contact the TPP via email to approve/disapprove the invoice. If the invoice is not approved, the State EF team member will communicate with the TPP on what adjustments need to be made in order to have an approvable invoice. The TPP will then have three business days to resubmit the invoice with corrections. The State EF team member will inform the TPP via email when the invoice has been approved, which will start the 45-day turnaround period for payment.

For more information on how TPPs should complete and submit the EF Invoice Template, EF Ledger Template, and Supporting Documentation to State EF staff for reimbursement, see the New FFY26 EF Invoice Process How-To ([Resource S](#)).

Colorado Benefits Management System (CBMS)

System Access. EF POs must follow all CDHS's CBMS policies. CBMS access is not to be shared among other EF PO employees. Each employee must have their own CBMS account. If you are a county DHS, please follow internal business processes to request CBMS access for a new employee.

TPP employees must submit a signed Statement of Compliance form ([Resource F](#)) and the CBMS Prerequisite Completion Certificate ([Resource G](#)) to the State EF team for all new employees. After the State EF team receives these two documents, the State EF team will submit these and a signed CBMS access form (Resource H) to the Office of Information Technology (OIT) Service Desk to initiate CBMS access. Please note: OIT

has a 7-10 business day turnaround for these requests. Once CBMS access has been created for the new TPP employee, the State EF team will forward the CBMS credentials to the employee. Once CBMS access is granted, the employee's responsibility is to attend a data entry training provided by the State EF team.

Data Entry. All EF POs must adhere to the CBMS data entry requirements outlined in the [EF Data Entry Desk Aid](#). In addition to this desk aid, EF POs are encouraged to contact their Partner Liaison and request technical assistance as needed.

Client Files

EF POs are required to maintain electronic files of EF client files. EF client files must include all supporting documentation for services/activities, case management actions, and supportive payments provided to the client. Supporting documentation should include but not be limited to: comprehensive employability assessments; ISPs; copies of sign-in sheets for workshops, training, or classes to document the client's level of effort; copies of attendance hours; case comments; and receipts or a State-approved Receipt Form for Supportive Payments ([Resource K](#)) used instead of receipts for supportive payments that are provided to clients.

Record Retention

EF POs are required to retain supporting documentation for all program services, operations, and invoices for up to four years. Additionally, should the State EF team request that EF POs provide supporting documentation, the EF PO must provide the documentation within three business days upon request.

Program Oversight Procedures

Program Operator Plans. County DHS and TPPs are required to submit EF PO Plans before the beginning of every program year. EF PO Plans are used to draft the State SNAP E&T plan that is then submitted to FNS.

The State EF team conducts technical assistance meetings, quarterly case file reviews, and reviews the [EF program partner data dashboards](#) to monitor all EF POs.

Program Spending. Every month, the State EF team also reviews expenditure levels for county human services departments, TPPs, and State administrative costs. This is accomplished via fiscal reports and invoice reviews of TPPs. When necessary, the State EF team will engage EF POs in conversation and technical assistance to address under- or over-spending.

Case File Reviews (Quarterly Oversight Process). The quarterly oversight process includes a review of one complete case file per partner and, if necessary, follow-up action when a required change is necessary in order to meet programmatic requirements for EF. The oversight process also provides ongoing training and

technical assistance, when needed, for services delivered to EF clients. For example, EF POs may ask for assistance on how to correctly document client progress in CBMS.

Quarterly Oversight Definitions

- **Agency Best Practices:** Internal policies and procedures that effectively support clients, ensure sound fiscal management, facilitate seamless referrals, and enhance case management practices.
- **Areas of Opportunity:** The State EF team's recommendations to improve program operations. While they are suggested enhancements, agencies are not required to take action on them.
- **Areas Requiring Change:** The State EF team's findings that are out of compliance with program policy and regulation. These may result in disallowed costs. To avoid a potential program breach, these areas must be resolved by the specified deadline.
- **Performance Finding:** An outstanding area requiring change that has not been closed within 30 days of issuance because no documentation was received, or the appropriate action to close the finding(s) was not taken. Performance findings may impact future allocations to TPPs or County EF PO plans and budgets.

Quarterly Oversight Timeline

Oversight case file reviews follow a set timeline each quarter for EF POs. The State EF team will request case file documentation on the 1st of the month.

EF POs then have until the 15th of that month to provide the requested documentation via encrypted email to the State EF team. Failure by the EF PO to provide the requested case file by the due date will result in a performance finding.

After documentation is provided, the State EF team will provide the EF PO with case file best practices, areas of opportunity, and areas requiring change (if applicable) by the 30th of that month.

Reference the [Monthly Employment First \(EF\) Program Operator \(PO\) Oversight Memo](#) for more details.

Management Evaluations (MEs). MEs are a federally required oversight component of the EF program. The State EF team determines EF POs that will undergo an ME based on criteria from the annual FNS target memo and notifies those who are selected for an ME during the first quarter of the FFY.

Selected EF POs also receive a formal ME letter requesting fiscal, program, and case file documentation for review to be submitted 60 days prior to the date of the ME. The State EF team aims to conduct MEs in person, but at times, MEs may be conducted through virtual meetings.

Within 30 days of an ME occurring, a report summarizing the ME will be sent to the EF PO. The EF PO also receives an action plan identifying agency best practices, areas for opportunity, and areas requiring change.

EF POs are provided a specified timeframe to address any areas requiring change that the State EF team then verifies. Failure to resolve any areas requiring change by their assigned due date will result in a performance finding, which may impact future allocations to TPPs or County EF PO plans and budgets.

Reference the [FFY2026 Employment First Management Evaluations Memo](#) for more details.

Please note that program requirements laid out in this handbook are in alignment with Colorado’s federally approved EF State Plan and the TPP Statement of Work and are subject to review in oversight and MEs.

Forms and Resources

The following forms and resources are referenced above in the handbook. For a more exhaustive list of helpful forms and resources for the EF program, please see the Resources section of the Colorado EF website.

Resource:	Description:
Resource A: Colorado EF website	EF POs, community partners, and clients may learn more about Colorado’s EF program.
Resource B: Promotional Flyer Instructions	EF POs must use the promotional flyer template provided by CDHS and are responsible for amending and maintaining the “For more information” section of the promotional flyer. The “For more information” section of the promotional flyer will contain the EF PO logo, EF PO’s contact information, and other relevant information (such as upcoming job fairs and new supportive payments so SNAP applicants/recipients can contact the EF program to engage with the services offered. The promotional flyer templates are available to download from page 2 of the Promotional Flyer Instructions. This can be used in conjunction with Resource C.
Resource C: EF Script	The purpose of this EF script is to provide guidance to EF PO workers to invite and refer clients into the EF program. This can be used in conjunction with Resource B.

Resource D: SNAP E&T Memos Folder	EF POs may find all relevant program memos stored here.
Resource E: EF Data Entry Desk Aid	CBMS is Colorado's statewide benefits system through which E&T services are provided and reported. This desk aid covers the data entry steps required by the EF PO.
Resource F: Statement of Compliance form	For TPP EF POs: The State EF team will submit this, the Prerequisite Completion Certificate, and the signed CBMS Access form to the OIT Service Desk to initiate CBMS access.
Resource G: Sample Prerequisite Completion Certificate	For TPP EF POs: The State EF team will submit this, the signed Statement of Compliance, and the signed CBMS Access form to the OIT Service Desk to initiate CBMS access.
Resource H: CBMS Access form (must request this form from State EF team)	For TPP EF POs: The State EF team will submit this, the signed Statement of Compliance, and the Prerequisite Completion Certificate to the OIT Service Desk to initiate CBMS access.
Resource I: EF PO Over the Cost Documentation	The purpose of this form is to document over-the-maximum-limit costs per client.
Resource J: Allowable Participant Reimbursements table	The purpose of this matrix is to inform EF POs what items are considered allowable supportive payments and, therefore, reimbursable utilizing Participant Reimbursement funding.
Resource K: Receipt Form for Supportive Payments	The purpose of this receipt form is to obtain confirmation from EF clients that they received the supportive payment that was provided to them from their EF PO. The form requires confirmation from both the EF PO and the EF client. EF PO must provide a wet signature, while the EF client can provide either a wet signature or email confirming they have received the identified supportive payment.
Resource L: EF Completed Activity Closure Reason Guide EF Closure Reasons - Not Completed and Unable to Complete Guide	The purpose of the first document is to provide short descriptions of Completed Closure Reasons for all allowable EF activities and what Closure Reason should be selected when a client successfully completes an activity. The purpose of the second document is to provide short descriptions of Not Completed and

	Unable to Complete Closure Reasons and to specify which Closure Reason should be selected when a client does not successfully complete, or is unable to successfully complete, an activity. This document also specifies which Closure Reasons should not be used by EF POs.
Resource M: Employment First Employability Assessment Spanish Employment First Employability Assessment	Comprehensive employability assessments must be conducted at the initial case management appointment and at least once every 365 days. If the EF PO does not have an approved employability assessment, they may use the State's version (English or Spanish).
Resource N: EF Workfare Toolkit	This toolkit can be used as a reference for the workfare options and for supporting clients during and after their workfare activities.
Resource O: Workfare Program (Site) Agreement	The purpose of this Agreement is to provide close and continuing cooperation between Workfare and the sponsor regarding the assignment of participants to specific worksites.
Resource P: Visual Aid: Activities & Closure Reasons Crosswalk	The purpose of this visual aid is to guide EF POs in entering successful outcomes into the CBMS, which will be reported on the Colorado Employment First Partner Data Dashboard.
Resource Q: Job Retention Decision Tree	The purpose of this decision tree is to guide EF POs in determining when a client can receive job retention services, for how long, and how to navigate this in CBMS.
Resource R: New FFY26 EF Invoice Process How-To	This step-by-step guide explains how TPPs should complete and submit the EF Invoice Template, EF Ledger Template, and Supporting Documentation to State EF staff for reimbursement.
Resource S: Supportive Payment Documentation Examples	The purpose of this document is to provide a list of examples of supportive payment documentation. Please note that this is not an exhaustive list.
Resource T: Employment First Reports & How to Subscribe	This resource outlines essential reports for EF POs and provides instructions for managing report subscriptions within CBMS.
Resource U: Employment First Case Comment Templates	This document provides case comment templates for EF clients in CBMS. The provided templates cover Screening and Referrals, PDs, and Regain.

	Case comments must always be individualized to each EF client.
Resource V: Employment First Onboarding Workfare Sites Toolkit	This new toolkit serves as a go-to resource for EF POs to provide a standardized framework for recruiting, onboarding, and managing Workfare sites for the Workfare Interim, Workfare Job Path, and Workfare Placement activities.